Social Reform Movements

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Introduction:

Impact of British Rule

✓ Social conditions like Religious and social ills, Depressing position of women, Caste system and opposition to western culture.
✓ New Awarness among Enlightened Indians.
✓ Two broad categories: Reformist movements like the Brahmo Samaj, the Prarthana Samaj and the Aligarh Movement.
✓ The Revivalist movements: such as the Arya Samaj, the Ramakrishna Mission and the Deoband Movement.
✓ There were also attempts to challenge the oppressive social structure by jyotiba Phule in Pune Narayana Guru and Ayyankali in Kerala and Ramalinga Adigal, Vaikunda Swamigal and Iyothee Thassar of Tamil Nadu.

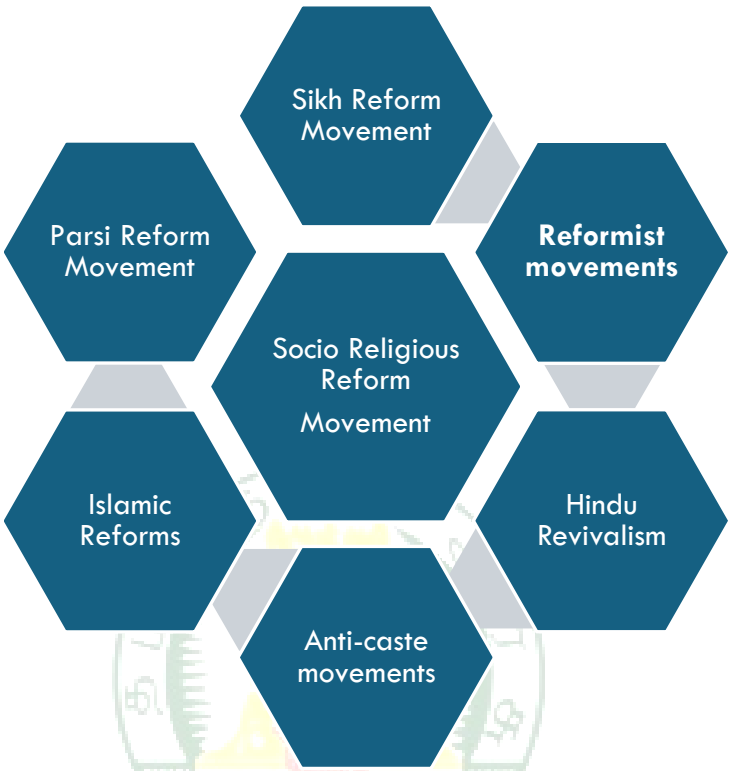
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Director,

Department of Employment and Training

Socio-Religious Reform Movement



Reformist movements

- Raja Rammohan Roy
- Maharishi Debendranath Tagore
- Keshab Chandra Sen
- Ishwar Chandra Vidyasaga

BRAHMO SAMAJ



Raja Rammohan Roy

Raja Rammohan Roy – A Pioneer Reformer

- Embraced **Western ideas** to initiate **social and religious reforms**
- A **scholar** fluent in **Sanskrit, Arabic, Persian, English, and Bengali**
- Opposed **meaningless religious rituals** and **harmful social customs**
- Advocated for **monotheism** and **anti-idolatry,** inspired by **Upanishadic thought**
- Sought to **balance reform with tradition,** preserving continuity with the past
- Believed Hindu scriptures upheld **worship of one God**

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Roy advocated for the **rights of widows to remarry** and called for an end to **polygamy**

- He published tracts against these practices and petitioned the government for reforms.

He published tracts against these practices and petitioned the government for reforms.

His efforts contributed to the **abolition of sati** through legislation passed by **Governor-General William Bentinck in 1829**

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Strong advocate for women's education

Supported the **introduction of English language** and **Western sciences** in schools and colleges

Founded the Brahmo Samaj in 1828

Opened a **temple in Calcutta** on 20 August 1828 with **no idols**

Advocated that **no religion should be ridiculed** or spoken of contemptuously

spoken of contemptuously

Forbade idol-worship and condemned **meaningless religious rites and ceremonies**

Initially, the Samaj's appeal was limited to **intellectuals and enlightened Bengalis**

Limited impact on lower sections of society, but had a **significant influence** on **modern Bengal's culture** and its **middle class**

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Maharshi debendranath tagore

- **Debendranath Tagore (1817–1905)** was the **father of poet Rabindranath Tagore.**
- He took over the reformist work after the death of **Raja Rammohan Roy in 1833.**
- He was a significant leader in the **Brahmo Samaj** movement, a monotheistic reformist movement within Hinduism.

Creation Belief → In the beginning, there was **nothing**; only the **One Supreme Being** existed, who **created the universe**

Nature of God → God is the **God of Truth, Infinite Wisdom, Goodness,** and **Power.** He is **eternal, omnipresent,** and **One without a second**

Path to Salvation → **Salvation** depends on **belief in God** and **worshiping Him** in this life and the next.

Essence of Belief → True belief lies in **loving God** and **doing His will.**

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Keshab Chandra Sen

Debendranath Tagore was a **moderate reformer** in the Brahmo Samaj

His **younger colleagues** wanted **faster and more radical changes**

Keshab Chandra Sen (1838–84) joined the Brahmo Samaj in **1857**

Keshab was **influenced by Christianity,** accepting its spirit but **not worshiping Christ as divine.**

In **1866,** a **split** occurred within the Brahmo Samaj.

Keshab Chandra Sen **left** and **founded a new organization**

Debendranath's group became known as the **Adi Brahmo Samaj.**

Keshab arranged the **marriage of his 14-year-old daughter** to an Indian prince, violating the **Samaj's stance against child marriage**

This led to another **split,** and the formation of the **Sadharan Brahmo Samaj.**

The **Sadharan Samaj** had **anti-Christian tendencies**

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Ishwar chandra vidyasagar

- ✓ **Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar (1820–1891)** was an **outstanding social reformer** in Bengal.
- ✓ Unlike others like **Raja Ram Mohan Roy,** who drew on **Western rationalism,** Vidyasagar emphasized that **Hindu scriptures were progressive.**
- ✓ He **provided scriptural evidence** against **sati (widow burning)** and the **prohibition of widow remarriage.**
- ✓ He was a **pioneer of modern Bengali prose** and wrote **polemical tracts.**
- ✓ He actively **promoted girls' education** and helped **set up schools** for them.

- ✓ He dedicated his life to **improving the condition of Hindu child widows.**
- ✓ His efforts led to the **Widows' Remarriage Act of 1856,** allowing **widow remarriage.**
- ✓ He was instrumental in the **Age of Consent Act (1860),** which initially **fixed the minimum marriage age at 10 years.**
- ✓ The age of marriage was later **raised to 12 in 1891** and **13 in 1925.**
- ✓ Despite these legal reforms, the **1929 Age of Consent Committee** reported that the **laws were largely ignored,** known only to a **small, educated minority.**

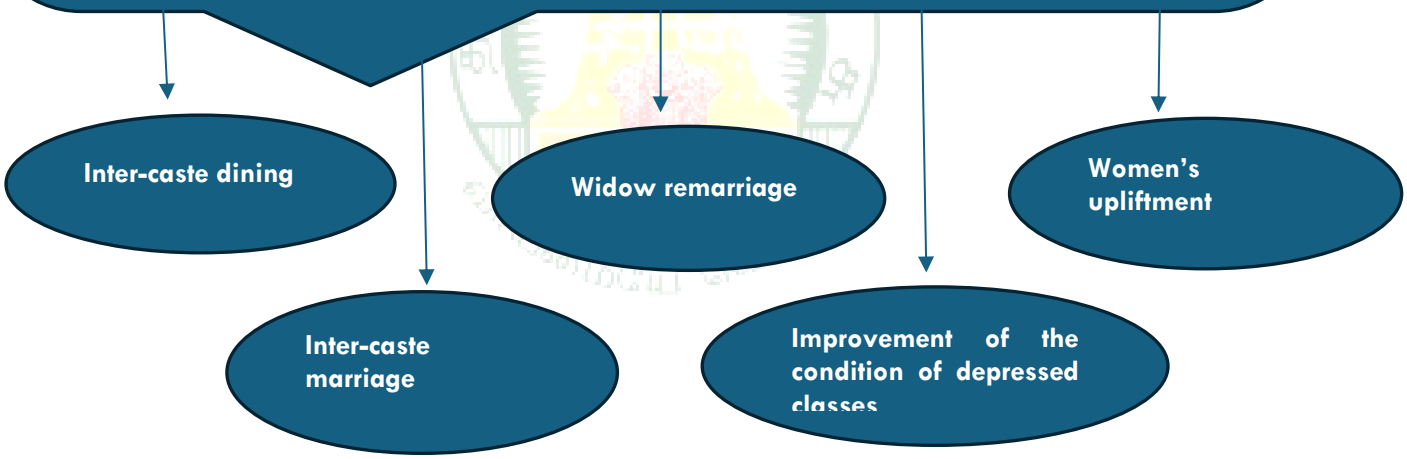
PRARTHANA SAMAJ

- **Maharashtra** saw significant **social reform movements** in the 19th century.
- **Prarthana Samaj,** similar to the Brahmo Samaj, was founded in **Bombay in 1867** by **Dr. Atma Ram Pandurang (1825–1898).**
- **Prominent members** of the Samaj included **R.C. Bhandarkar** and **Justice Mahadev Govind Ranade.**

Justice M.G. Ranade (1842–1901) was the founder of:

- **Widow Marriage Association (1861)**
- **Poona Sarvajanik Sabha (1870)**
- **Deccan Education Society (1884)**

- Their reform efforts focused on



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Hindu Revivalism

- Swami Dayanand Saraswati
- Ramakrishna
- Swami Vivekananda
- Theosophical Movement



Swami dayanand saraswati

Arya Samaj led the reform movement in Punjab.

It was founded in 1875 by Swami Dayanand Saraswati (1824–1883).

Swami Dayanand was a wandering ascetic who later settled in Punjab to spread his ideas

His major work, Satyarth Prakash, gained wide popularity.

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n 1893, Arya Samaj split over the issue of doctrinal purity.

Swami Shraddhananda (1857–1926), a key leader post-Dayanand, criticized the Western influence in DAV schools.

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He rejected:

- Child marriage
- Ban on widow remarriage
- Belief that foreign travel was polluting
- Idolatry
- Brahmin dominance in rituals and social life
- Puranic literature and superstition

He promoted

- **Strict monotheism**
- **Return to Vedic principles ("Go back to the Vedas")**



Ramakrishna

- The Brahmo Samaj had earlier criticized idolatry and orthodox Hindu practices in response to Christian and rationalist criticism.
- Ramakrishna was a devotee of Goddess Kali, viewing her as the divine mother with infinite manifestations.
- He believed all religions share universal truths and, when practiced sincerely, could lead to salvation.
- **"Jiva is Siva" –** all living beings are manifestations of God.
- Instead of showing mercy, one should serve humanity, as service to man is service to God.

Some people were dissatisfied with the rational and reformist approach of organizations like the Brahmo Samaj.

After Ramakrishna's death in 1886, his disciples formed a religious community to spread his teachings.

The main force behind this effort was Swami Vivekananda.

Vivekananda modeled the organization after Christian missionary structures.

He founded the Ramakrishna Mission, which went beyond religious work to engage in social service, including:

- Education
- Health care
- Disaster relief during calamities.

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Swami Vivekananda

- Swami Vivekananda (1863–1902), born Narendra Nath Datta, was the chief disciple of Ramakrishna Paramahansa
- He was an educated youth inspired by Ramakrishna's spiritual message.
- He promoted Practical Vedanta, focusing on service to humanity rather than ritualism
- Vivekananda championed cultural nationalism and urged Indian youth to reform Hindu society.
- Vivekananda championed cultural nationalism and urged Indian youth to reform Hindu society.

  His teachings helped boost Indian self-confidence, countering feelings of inferiority to the West.
- He gained international fame for his 1893 speech on Hinduism at the World Parliament of Religions in Chicago.

  Orthodox Hindus opposed him for advocating lower caste participation in Hindu rituals.

THEOSOPHICAL SOCIETY

Role of the Theosophical Society	The Theosophical Society played a major role in promoting Eastern spirituality.
Founders	The Theosophical Society played a major role in promoting Eastern spirituality.
Foundation and relocation	Established in the USA in 1875, the society shifted to India (Adyar, Chennai) in 1886.
Impact	The Society helped in reviving interest and respect for Hindu philosophy and culture, both in India and abroad.
Revival of Buddhism	It also played a significant role in the revival of Buddhism in India.



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Anti-caste

- Jyotiba Phule
- Narayana Guru
- Ayyankali



Swami Vivekananda

Birth and background	**Born in 1827 in Maharashtra, Jyotiba Phule was a pioneer of the non-Brahman movement**
Education for untouchables	He opened the first school for "untouchables" in 1852 in Poona (Pune)
Satyashodak Samaj	Founded the Satyashodak Samaj (Truth-Seekers Society) in 1870 to promote self-respect and empowerment among non-Brahmans
Social reformer	• Opposed child marriage. • Supported widow remarriage, especially where it was forbidden among high-caste Hindus
Work with Savitribai Phule	Together with his wife, Savitribai Phule, he uplifted depressed classes and women, and opened orphanages and homes for widows
View on British rule:	Unlike many nationalists, he welcomed British rule and missionary work because they helped **the lower castes challenge Brahmin dominance**
Major work	Unlike many nationalists, he welcomed British rule and missionary work because they helped the lower castes challenge Brahmin dominance

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Narayana guru

Birth and background	**Born in 1854 to poor parents in Kerala, Narayana Guru became a scholar and poet in Malayalam, Tamil, and Sanskrit.**
Social inequality	In his time, **lower castes were denied access** to: • **Education** • **Temples, streets, public tanks/wells** • **Wearing upper garments** (especially for women)
Life's mission	Deeply disturbed by **caste-based oppression,** he **dedicated his life to uplifting the oppressed classes**
Organization founded	Deeply disturbed by **caste-based oppression,** he **dedicated his life to uplifting the oppressed classes**
Temple at Aruvipuram	Built a **temple open to all castes,** symbolizing **spiritual equality**
Impact on Kerala society	Brought about a **radical transformation,** especially for the **Ezhava community.** Influenced reformers and intellectuals like **Kumaran Asan** and **Dr. Palpu**



Ayyankali

- Ayyankali (1863–1941) and Narayana Guru were central figures in fighting caste oppression.
- Ayyankali was born in 1863 in Venganoor, Thiruvananthapuram, in the princely state of Travancore.
- Advocated for access to public spaces and school entry for lower castes
- Wearing upper-caste-style clothing.
- Riding an ox-cart on public roads, defying bans on lower castes.
- Inspired by Narayana Guru:
  Founded the Sadhu Jana Paripalana Sangam in 1907, to:
  Campaign for lower caste rights
  Raise funds for educating the Pulaya communit

Islamic Reforms

Feature	Aligarh Movement	Deoband Movement
Founder	Sir Sayyid Ahmed Khan	Muhammad Qasim Nanotavi, Rashid Ahmad Gangohi
Founded in	1875 (college), Aligarh	1866, Deoband (U.P.)
Education approach	Pro-Western, modern, English-based	Anti-Western, Islamic religious education
Political stance	Pro-British, anti-nationalist	Anti-British, supported Indian nationalism
Anti-British, supported Indian nationalism	Aligarh Muslim University	Darul Uloom Deoband

Parsi Reform Movement

Rahnumai Mazdayasnan Sabha (1851)

└──── Founded by Furdunji Naoroji

├──── Publication: Rast Goftar ("The Truth Teller")

├──── Key Reform Issues:

│ ├──── Opposed elaborate rituals (marriage, funerals)

│ ├──── Opposed infant marriage

│ └──── Rejected astrology

- Behrramji Malabari
  - Campaign against child marriage
- Leaders in Nationalism:
  - Pherozeshah Mehta
  - Dinshaw Wacha

Sikh Reform Movements

Nirankari Movement

- Focus: Spiritual purity, monotheism, social reform

- **Namdhari Movement** (Founded by Baba Ram Singh)
  - Replaced kirpan with lathi
  - Advocated equality of sexes
  - Supported widow remarriage
  - Opposed dowry system
  - Opposed child marriage

- **Singh Sabha Movement** (Amritsar)
  - Founded in response to Arya Samaj & missionaries
  - Goal: Restore purity of Sikhism
    - Established Khalsa College (with British support)
  - Forerunner of the Akali Movement

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Social Reformers of Tamilnadu

- Ramalinga Swamigal
- Vaikunda Swamikal
- C. Iyothee Thassar



Ramalinga Swamigal (Vallalar) (1823–1874

Birth	• Born in Marudhur, near Chidambaram • Moved to Chennai after father's death • No formal education, yet became a scholar
Core Philosophy	Emphasized compassion (Jeevakarunya) Believed lack of compassion clouds wisdom
Social Reforms	• Founded Samarasa Vedha Sanmarga Sangam (1865) • └—— Later renamed "Samarasa Suddha Sanmarga Satya Sanga" • Started free feeding house at Vadalur (1867) • └——— In response to the 1866 famine • Promoted universal brotherhood and compassion beyond caste
Literary Contributions	• Composed spiritual songs compiled as **Thiruvarutpa** (Songs of Grace) • Condemned by Saiva orthodoxy as "Marutpa" (songs of ignorance)
Empathy for the Poor	• Witnessed extreme hunger and poverty • Felt intense emotional and moral suffering

	• Used his spiritual and social platform to promote relief and equality



Vaikunda Swamikal

Birth	• Born in Sasthan Koil Vilai (now Samithoppu), near Kanyakumari • Original name: Mudichudum Perumal → changed to **Muthukutty**
Core Philosophy	• Preached **equality and rights** for depressed classes • Opposed British rule ("White devils") & Travancore monarchy ("Black devils") • Experienced a divine vision at Tiruchendur, renamed himself **Vaikundar**
Social Reforms	• **Criticized caste discrimination and religious ritualism** • Condemned **idol worship, animal sacrifice, and superstitions** • Promoted **rational and ethical worship**
Initiatives	• Samathuva Samajam (Society for Social Equality) └——— Promoted **inter-caste unityand, inter-dining** • 1833: Began meditation at Samithoppu for **caste abolition** • Founded the **Ayya Vazhi** movement (Path of Ayya) • Followers respectfully called him **Ayya** (Father) • His teachings compiled in Akila **Thirattu**

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Iyothee Thassar

Birth	• Born in Chennai (original name: Ivothithassar) • Scholar in Tamil, English, Sanskrit & Pali • Siddha practitioner, writer, journalist
Social Reforms	• **Established schools for "untouchables"** • **Promoted casteless identity and social justice**
Founded	• Advaidananda Sabha (temple entry rights) • Dravida Kazhagam (1882, with John Rathinam) • Dravida Pandian magazine (1885) • Dravida Mahajana Sabha (1891)
Religious Reform – Embrace of Buddhism	• Influenced by Colonel H.S. Olcott (Theosophist) • Converted to Buddhism in Sri Lanka (1898) • Founded **Sakya Buddhist Society** in Madras • Reinterpreted Tamil history as **originally Buddhist** • Called untouchables "Sathi Petham Atra Dravidar" (Casteless Dravidians)
Publications	• Started **Oru Paisa Tamilan** weekly journal (1907–1914)